

How One Objective Setting Hid Half a Meta Budget

Two campaigns, one account, same audience pool, same launch day. One of them bought nearly twice the audience and recorded no enquiries at all. The account-level report showed a single blended number that described neither campaign.

Client: A local dental practice**Industry:** Healthcare**Service:** Meta Ads**Window:** August 2026, 27 spending days**\$15.77**

ACTUAL COST PER ENQUIRY

\$30.65

WHAT THE ROLLUP REPORTED

49,760

IMPRESSIONS, NO ENQUIRIES

49%OF SPEND ON THE WRONG
EVENT

THE SETUP

One Variable, Held Clean

The account ran two campaigns side by side for the full month. Same account, same audience pool, same launch day, same budget to within a hundred dollars. The only difference between them was the conversion event each one was told to optimize toward. One was set to Engagement. One was set to Leads.

THE SPLIT

What Each Objective Actually Bought

CAMPAIGN OBJECTIVE	SPEND	IMPRESSIONS	CLICKS	ENQUIRIES	COST PER ENQUIRY
Engagement	\$1,845.88	49,760	1,584	0 recorded	n/a
Leads	\$1,955.17	26,721	1,087	124	\$15.77
Blended, as the account reported it	\$3,801.05	76,481	2,671	124	\$30.65

Campaign Objective

Conversion Event

Account Diagnostics

Meta Ads

Reporting Integrity

WHY IT MATTERS

The Blended Number Described Neither Campaign

1.9x

More Audience, No Enquiries

The Engagement campaign bought nearly twice the impressions and more clicks than the campaign that produced every enquiry in the account.

2x

Overstated Cost Per Enquiry

Read from the account rollup alone, enquiries appeared to cost \$30.65. The campaign actually producing them was running at \$15.77.

What this case study does not claim

An Engagement objective would not record lead events in the first place, and this account had no call tracking, so we cannot show that the Engagement campaign drove zero phone calls. The defensible finding is that it produced not one recorded enquiry, and that no mechanism existed to prove otherwise. The measurement gap and the performance gap were the same gap.

Both campaigns stopped spending at the end of this window, so the figures describe one month and are not presented as a trend.

CREEKSIDE MARKETING

Do you know which conversion event your budget is actually buying?

Figures pulled from the advertising platform's own reporting for the campaign window described and verified against account records on 24 September 2026. Client identity withheld; this account is active. Across roughly 1,825 Meta campaigns managed by Creekside Marketing, fewer than one in ten runs on an engagement or video objective.